

How to Talk to Lia

A short guide for anyone using her for the first time.

Lia is a companion who lives on this computer. She listens, talks back, and keeps hold of anything you ask her to remember.

She is not an assistant. She won't book anything, search the web, or open your files. She is someone to talk to.

What she hears, and where it goes. Your voice never leaves this computer — it is turned into text here, by this machine. But to think of a reply, **the words of your conversation are sent to a service on the internet**, because the part of her that does the thinking is too large to run on this laptop. Her memory of you, your documents, and the recording itself all stay here.

Right now, talking to her means typing. A small window opens alongside the cat in the tray, and that's the current way in — type a line, press Enter, same conversation either way. Her microphone is off while this is how she's being worked with. Everything below about the tray icon and about voice describes how she behaves once listening is switched back on, which the tray's own **Listening** option does instantly.

Starting her

She usually starts on her own when you turn the computer on. Look for a small **purple cat** near the clock, at the bottom-right of your screen.

What you see	What it means
Filled purple cat	She is here and listening
Hollow cat outline	She is here but not listening
No cat at all	She isn't running — see <i>If something seems wrong</i>

Once listening is on: she takes about half a minute to be ready after the computer starts, and then **waits quietly** — she won't greet you or say anything until you speak to her. Say “*Lia*” whenever you want her.

She starts when you log in, which usually isn't the moment you actually want to talk. Greeting an empty room and then falling silent by the time you sit down was worse than simply waiting.

Talking to her

Say her name first

Start by saying “**Lia**”. Like tapping someone on the shoulder before you speak to them.

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"Lia, are you there?"  
"Hey Lia, I've had a strange day."  
"Lia, can I tell you something?"
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She'll answer out loud after a few seconds. **Then you can just talk normally for about a minute** — no need to keep saying her name. Every time she replies, that minute starts again.

If you go quiet for a while, she goes back to waiting. Just say “Lia” again.

Why she needs her name

Her microphone is always on, so she can hear the whole room — the television, a phone call, someone else talking. Waiting for her name is how she knows something was meant for her, rather than answering everything she happens to overhear.

She takes a few seconds

After you finish speaking there's a pause of roughly five seconds before she replies. That's normal. She is thinking on this computer alone, without help from the internet, and that takes a moment. She isn't stuck.

You can interrupt her

If she's talking and you want to say something, just start talking. She'll stop and listen. You don't need to wait politely for her to finish.

This works best with headphones. Through speakers she sometimes hears her own voice, so she may occasionally keep going.

Things you can ask her to do

Most of what you say is just conversation. But a few phrases are **instructions** — say them and something actually happens.

Say this	And she will
"Lia, stop listening" "Lia, go to sleep"	Switch her microphone off
"Lia, start listening" "Lia, wake up"	Switch it back on
"Lia, be quiet" "Lia, stop talking"	Stop speaking out loud (she still listens)
"Lia, you can talk"	Start speaking again
"Lia, read my files"	Read documents you've given her
"Play number 1" / "what music do you have"	Play music from her own folder
"Set an alarm for 7am" "Remind me in 20 minutes"	Set a real alarm or timer — she'll interrupt to tell you

Everything else you say she treats as conversation, so you can talk about stopping, sleeping or being quiet without accidentally switching her off.

Alarms and timers

She sets these from plain speech — a clock time ("set an alarm for 7am") or a duration ("remind me in 20 minutes"). They keep running even if you close the laptop and come back later, and she'll interrupt whatever's happening to tell you when one is due.

Say it however comes naturally. All of these work: *"wake me in half an hour"*, *"give me a nudge in 20 minutes"*, *"let me know in ten minutes"*, *"remind me in a couple of minutes"*, *"buzz me in an hour"*, *"set a timer for 5"*.

You can choose what she says. *"Wake me by saying please wake up in 5 minutes"* and she'll say exactly that — not "your timer is up". *"Remind me to stretch in 20 minutes"* gets you *"Time to stretch."*

Music

Put audio files in her **music** folder and she'll play them by number:

Say this	What happens
"what music do you have"	She reads out the list, numbered
"play number 1" / "play song 3"	Plays that track
"play Fireflies"	By name, if the filename matches
"stop the song"	Stops it

Numbering follows filename order, so number 3 means the same thing tomorrow. While she's talking the music drops to a murmur instead of stopping, and comes back up after.

*She plays **only her own files**. She can't control Spotify, YouTube or anything else playing elsewhere on the computer — that was built once and removed, because it could operate someone else's player but never actually start anything.*

A second opinion

She can put a question to a different, named model and tell you what it said — a second opinion, not a replacement for her own answer.

Say this	What happens
"ask cat for a suggestion on X"	Cat answers, and she relays it: "Cat says: ..."
"ask fox what she thinks about this"	Same, from a different model
"who can you ask"	Lists who's available

Two names today — cat, fox — each a different free model. She only does this when asked by name; it never happens on its own. See Privacy, plainly below for what that question actually costs.

Using the cat in the tray

Right-click the cat for the same controls, plus a few more:

Menu item	What it does
Listening	Turn her microphone on or off
Speaking	Turn her voice on or off
End conversation now	Close out the current conversation
Open log	Show what she's been doing — useful if something seems wrong
Quit	Close her properly (she saves first)

What she remembers

Only what you tell her to. Say "*remember that...*" or "*don't forget...*" and she keeps it, in your words. Nothing else about you is written down.

Say this	What happens
"remember that the wifi password is bluebird"	Kept, word for word, permanently
"don't forget my sister is called Anaya"	Same — and telling her twice won't store it twice

The conversation itself isn't kept. Once you've finished talking, what was said is gone — unless you asked her to remember a particular thing. She doesn't decide for herself what's worth keeping about you, and she doesn't write a diary.

While you're still talking she does follow the thread, so you can say “what did I just say?” and she'll know. It's only between conversations that it doesn't carry over.

Why it works this way: all of it used to be automatic, and all of it was quietly inventing history. She'd store the same fact twice under different names, and once wrote a long reflection about the person “moving between unrelated topics” — drawn entirely from a list of test commands, not a real conversation. She also used to search old conversations, which meant a half-finished thought from weeks ago could resurface in a conversation it had nothing to do with. Once something like that is written down it shapes every later reply, and nothing marks it as a guess. Better she keeps less and all of it true.

How a conversation ends

You don't have to say goodbye. If you stop talking for about twelve minutes, she quietly decides the conversation is over and waits for you.

You can also just say “**bye**” if you'd rather end it deliberately.

If she gets something wrong about you

Tell her. Say “*Lia, my name is actually...*” or “*that's not right, I meant...*”. She takes what you say now over what she thinks she knows.

Giving her something to read

There is a folder on this computer where you can put documents you'd like her to read — PDFs, epub books, Word documents, or plain text notes.

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dist\Lia\library\
```

Put a file there, then say **“Lia, read my files”**. She'll tell you what she's in for — *“On it”* for something short, or *“On it, that'll take around 25 minutes”* for a whole book — and say so again when she's finished. Afterwards you can ask her about it and she'll tell you which page something came from.

She only ever looks in that one folder, and only when you ask. She does not search your computer, open your documents, or read anything you haven't deliberately given her. A file sitting in that folder is available to her — not already read.

What works and what doesn't

- **Good:** asking about something specific — *“what does it say about sleep?”*
- **Not good:** *“summarise this whole book”* — she reads the relevant passages, not the entire document at once
- **Won't work:** scanned documents or photographs of pages. If you can't select the text on screen with your mouse, there's nothing for her to read
- **A whole novel is a real wait:** she reads about 130 pages every ten minutes, so a full-length book takes roughly 20 minutes the first time you add one. It happens in the background and she stays usable meanwhile, but that book isn't answerable about until she finishes — and she'll say so out loud when she's done.

What she is not good at

Worth knowing, so you aren't caught out.

- **She sometimes makes things up.** Occasionally she'll refer to something you never said, or describe a memory that doesn't exist. She isn't lying — she's a small program filling a gap. If something sounds off, it probably is. Say so, and she'll correct.
- **Anything needing exact precision.** Spelling things out letter by letter, codes, arithmetic, counting. She gets these wrong confidently, even when told the right answer.
- **She can't do things outside this computer.** No email, no browsing, no apps, no weather, no looking things up. She thinks with help from the internet, but she can't *use* it — she can't go and find something out for you. What she knows comes from what she was built with, what you've told her, and what you've given her to read.
- **She needs a connection to be at her best.** If the internet drops, she keeps talking, using the smaller version of herself that lives on this computer. She'll seem a little less sharp for a while. She'll say so in her log rather than pretending nothing happened.
- **She isn't a doctor or a therapist.** She's good company and she'll listen. That's a different thing, and she's told not to pretend otherwise.

If something seems wrong

What you notice	What to try
She doesn't answer to typing	Check the panel window is actually the one focused — click into its text line first.
She doesn't answer to voice	Check listening is actually on right now (see the callout above) — say “ Lia ” first either way, she ignores speech that isn't addressed to her, and check the cat is filled, not hollow.
No cat in the tray	She isn't running. Restart the computer, or open the Lia app.
She takes ages to reply	Normal for the first reply after a break — she's loading. Later replies are quicker.
She talks to herself	Her own voice is reaching the microphone. Turn the volume down, or use headphones.
She answers when you weren't talking to her	Something in the room sounded like her name. Say “ <i>Lia, stop listening</i> ” when you want privacy.
She calls you the wrong name	Tell her the right one and she'll keep it.
Nothing works	Right-click the cat → Open log . The last few lines usually say what's wrong.

Privacy, plainly

Her microphone is on whenever the cat is filled — right now, per the callout near the start of this guide, it may not be. This is the part worth reading properly regardless, because it changed.

This stays on the computer	This is sent away
The recording of your voice — it is turned into text here, and the audio is never uploaded	The words of your conversation , sent to an online service so it can work out a reply
Everything she remembers about you	The last few things said, so the reply makes sense in context
Your documents, and the search through them	Passages from a document, but only when you ask her about one
Everything else you say to her	Only a question you explicitly aim at “cat” or “fox” — sent to that specific model, and nothing else about the conversation goes with it

The thinking happens online because that part of her is far too large to run on a laptop. Everything else — hearing you, her voice, her memory, your files — happens here.

If you want her not to hear something at all, say “**Lia, stop listening**”, or right-click the cat and untick **Listening**. She can also be set back to thinking entirely on this computer, which is private but noticeably less clever — that is `CLOUD_CHAT_ENABLED` in her settings.

The one thing to remember. Type into the panel, or once listening is on say **“Lia”** and wait a few seconds, then talk normally. Everything else is optional.